Module 5 · Workbook answers

# How to maintain balance

Video: 50 min **Answer sheet**

You now have a clear plan for change, but excelling in one area of life while neglecting the others is not true success. This module introduces the Seven Trees of Balance (Spirit, Family, Provision, Learning, Health, Social Interaction and Service) and the one statement that unites them all: La ilaha illallah.

**Answer sheet:** the answers are in red. The reflection questions are personal, so your own answers will be in your own words and from your own life. These model answers show what the session teaches, to guide and check your thinking.

## Key teachings

1 **One area is not enough**

By now you have everything you need to make changes, yet many of us excel in just one area of life. A full life means wellbeing in many dimensions: plant seven seeds and tend each tree, because a neglected tree dies. Think of a car: clean it and fill it with petrol, but forget the oil or coolant and it still breaks down, and a human being is far more complex. The Qur'an warns of the greatest losers, whose effort is lost in this life while they think they are doing well.

2 **The tree of the Spirit**

The first and most important tree has four parts. Meaning: every part of you has a purpose (your eyes, ears and tongue), so how could the whole of you have none? A relationship with Allah: not only prayer and Qur'an, but an active relationship where you ask and He gives, and you seek His guidance. Purpose: a mission beyond looking after yourself and your family. Inner peace: "I'm stuck at home, I wish I could travel" is an artificial goal. With deep meaning and purpose, everything has meaning, even cleaning the toilet.

3 **The tree of Family**

Some of the wealthiest people have broken families, with children who no longer speak to them. This tree grows in four stages. Love and care, from picking up your baby when they cry. Fulfilling rights: food, protection and shelter for children, and the rights of our spouses, where we often fall short and about which we will be asked. Strong ties built through time: asked who they would most like to have dinner with, children name their parents. Joy and stability: real fun together. It is reported that the Prophet ﷺ kept time for his family that other matters did not crowd out.

4 **The trees of Provision and Learning**

Provision (rizq) is already written: Allah asks us not for provision; He provides for us. So do not stress over it. Be skilful in lawful work and worry less about how much you earn than about reflecting Allah's attributes in how you work. Intend to sustain your family and help society, and spot chances to help people just as you spot chances to make money. Learning keeps you sharp for life: expand your knowledge, try new experiences and put what you learn into practice. This builds hikmah (wisdom: knowing what to do, when and how), for which Luqman, who has a surah named after him, was known. If you have not improved, do not give up on yourself; find what you struggled with and work on it.

**5** **The trees of Health and Social Interaction**

A saying goes that health is a crown on the heads of the healthy that only the sick can see; once it is gone, money cannot buy it back. Do a little exercise you can keep up, rather than bursts at the gym. Review your food: cultural favourites are tasty, but why not enjoy the fruit and vegetables Allah has given us instead of highly processed food? Tend to your mental and emotional wellbeing before it gets bad. Social interaction reaches beyond the family to neighbours, friends and community; a long-running Harvard study found close relationships are among the strongest links to a happy, long life, and praying at the mosque keeps you connected. Care for animals and the environment too, and look for ways to help, like a network of sisters who cook for a woman who is pregnant.

**6** **The tree of Service, and replanting what is neglected**

Service is your wider mission: serving humanity with a skill you already have. It need not reach the whole world. The Prophet's ﷺ call began privately: a small group was transformed, and they changed the world. The marker of a person of service is compassion for all of Allah's creation. A neglected tree leaves you empty and hollow: poor health stops everything, a home on fire undoes your good work outside, no service makes life selfish, and with no friends nobody visits when you are ill. You need not water every tree daily, just keep an eye on them all. If one is dead, plant a seed and install it over 30 days, for example by volunteering in an existing community activity.

**7** **One mission statement: La ilaha illallah**

One mission statement unites all seven trees: La ilaha illallah, there is no god but Allah. Everything in the trees is creation, and none of it is God: not money, not your health, not you. The Prophet ﷺ warned that the slave of the dinar (the one who worships money) is wretched. As you say "La ilaha", pull out every false god, which usually sits in one of the trees (perhaps provision is leading you to materialism, a love of fame or even unlawful things), and throw it out. As you say "illallah", install Allah alone in your heart. With family, we forget our spouse is part of this world and will never be perfect. Family is a test, so ask: "Am I fulfilling my rights and responsibilities towards them?"

**8** **Let go of "what if", and start small**

The Prophet ﷺ taught that "if" opens the door to Shaytan: what if I had married someone else, or taken another job? The friends of Allah neither fear nor grieve. Be ibn al-waqt, a person of the present, the only time you can affect. Count what you have (safety, food for today, your faith), as few of Allah's servants are truly grateful. To avoid overwhelm, start with the two practices from last time: long periods of silence (when the children are shouting, go silent and reflect) and leaving everything better than you found it, even your own body each day. Those who fear their Lord will be driven to Paradise in groups, so travel this path together.

## From the Qur'an, the Sunnah and the scholars

قُلْ هَلْ نُنَبِّئُكُمْ بِٱلْأَخْسَرِينَ أَعْمَـٰلًا ۝ ٱلَّذِينَ ضَلَّ سَعْيُهُمْ فِى ٱلْحَيَوٰةِ ٱلدُّنْيَا وَهُمْ يَحْسَبُونَ أَنَّهُمْ يُحْسِنُونَ صُنْعًا

*Say, [O Muḥammad], "Shall we [believers] inform you of the greatest losers as to [their] deeds? [They are] those whose effort is lost in worldly life, while they think that they are doing well in work."*

**Surah Al-Kahf 18:103–104**

وَأْمُرْ أَهْلَكَ بِٱلصَّلَوٰةِ وَٱصْطَبِرْ عَلَيْهَا ۖ لَا نَسْـَٔلُكَ رِزْقًا ۖ نَّحْنُ نَرْزُقُكَ ۗ وَٱلْعَـٰقِبَةُ لِلتَّقْوَىٰ

*And enjoin prayer upon your family [and people] and be steadfast therein. We ask you not for provision; We provide for you, and the [best] outcome is for [those of] righteousness.*

**Surah Ta-Ha 20:132**

وَٱلْعَصْرِ ۝ إِنَّ ٱلْإِنسَـٰنَ لَفِى خُسْرٍ ۝ إِلَّا ٱلَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا۟ وَعَمِلُوا۟ ٱلصَّـٰلِحَـٰتِ وَتَوَاصَوْا۟ بِٱلْحَقِّ وَتَوَاصَوْا۟ بِٱلصَّبْرِ

*By time, indeed, mankind is in loss, except for those who have believed and done righteous deeds and advised each other to truth and advised each other to patience.*

**Surah Al-'Asr 103:1–3**

أَلَآ إِنَّ أَوْلِيَآءَ ٱللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ۝ ٱلَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا۟ وَكَانُوا۟ يَتَّقُونَ

*Unquestionably, [for] the allies of Allāh there will be no fear concerning them, nor will they grieve - those who believed and were fearing Allāh.*

**Surah Yunus 10:62–63**

> *There are two blessings which many people lose: health and free time.*
>
> **Sahih al-Bukhari**

> *If anything befalls you, do not say, "If only I had done such and such," but say, "Allah has decreed, and what He wills He does," for "if" opens the door to the work of Shaytan.*
>
> **Sahih Muslim**

## Practical exercises

**My Seven Trees of Balance**

1. Score each tree from 1 (neglected, close to dying) to 10 (strong and flourishing): Spirit ___ Family ___ Provision ___ Learning ___ Health ___ Social interaction ___ Service ___
2. Next to your two lowest scores, write in a few words why that tree has been neglected.
3. Circle the one tree you most want to grow. This is your seed to plant.
4. Write one small, specific step for that tree that you can repeat for 30 days (for example, a protected half hour with your family each evening, or a short daily walk).
5. Note the date you will start and who might help you keep going.

**La ilaha illallah: clearing out false gods**

1. Sit quietly and look across the seven trees. Ask: which part of creation is dictating my choices (money, career, image, a person, my own comfort)?
2. Write down what that false god makes you think, feel or do.
3. Slowly say "La ilaha" and picture pulling it out of your heart, mind and stomach and throwing it away.
4. Then say "illallah" and picture Allah alone in your heart.
5. Write how you will now treat that thing: as a trust and a test, not as something to worship.

**From "what if" to "what now"**

1. Write down one "what if" about the past that keeps coming back, and next to it: "Allah has decreed, and what He wills He does."
2. List five blessings you have today that you usually overlook (safety, health, food for today, your faith, your family).
3. Ask yourself: what is the one thing I can do now, today, that I can actually affect? Write it down and do it.

## My week of balance

Tick each day you practise.

| | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Long periods of silence: Allah sees and hears me | | | | | | | |
| Left people (and my body) better than I found them | | | | | | | |
| Watered the tree I chose to grow | | | | | | | |
| Said La ilaha illallah with presence | | | | | | | |

## Reflection questions and answers

**1.** Which one area of your life do you tend to excel in, and which tree has quietly been neglected because of it?

> The session warns that excelling in one area while neglecting the others is not true success, like a car that is cleaned and filled with petrol but still breaks down because the oil was forgotten. A good answer names your strongest tree and honestly names the one that has suffered for it. For example: I put everything into my provision and career, and my health tree has been neglected; I rarely exercise and eat mostly processed food.

**2.** If you looked back at the end of your life, which tree would you most regret not tending?

> This question echoes the warning in Surah Al-Kahf about those whose effort is lost in this life while they think they are doing well. Look across all seven trees (Spirit, Family, Provision, Learning, Health, Social Interaction and Service) and ask which one you would grieve over most if it died. For example: I would most regret the Family tree, because I fear my children will remember me as busy rather than present.

**3.** What gives your everyday tasks meaning? Which of them feel empty, and why?

> In the tree of the Spirit, meaning comes first: every part of you has a purpose, so the whole of you must have one too. When life is connected to a deep purpose and a living relationship with Allah, even cleaning the toilet has meaning; tasks feel empty when they are cut off from that purpose. For example: cooking feels meaningful when I intend it as fulfilling my family's rights, but answering emails feels empty because I do it on autopilot.

**4.** When did you last give your family protected, undistracted time, and what got in the way?

> The tree of Family grows through love and care, fulfilling rights, strong ties built through time, and joy and stability. Children asked who they would most like to have dinner with name their parents, and it is reported that the Prophet ﷺ kept time for his family that other matters did not crowd out. For example: the last real family time I had was a walk in the park two weeks ago; since then my phone and late work have got in the way.

**5.** What skill do you already have that could be used to serve others?

> Service is your wider mission: serving humanity with a skill you already have, and it does not need to reach the whole world. The Prophet's ﷺ call began with a small group who were transformed, and the marker of a person of service is compassion for all of Allah's creation. For example: I am a good cook, so I could join the sisters in my area who cook meals for a woman who is pregnant.

**6.** Which part of creation has become a "false god" for you, and how does it show in your choices?

> La ilaha illallah asks us to pull out every false god, which usually sits in one of the trees: money, career, image, a person or our own comfort. Everything in the trees is creation and none of it is God, and the Prophet ﷺ warned that the slave of the dinar is wretched. For example: money has become a false god for me; it shows when I delay prayers to finish work, or feel anxious every time I check my bank balance.

**7.** Which "what if" from the past keeps pulling you away from what you can do today?

> The Prophet ﷺ taught that "if" opens the door to the work of Shaytan, so instead we say, "Allah has decreed, and what He wills He does." The friends of Allah neither fear nor grieve; the aim is to be ibn al-waqt, a person of the present, counting the blessings we have today. For example: I keep thinking, "What if I had taken that other job?", when what I can do today is excel in the work I have.

**8.** Where in your life could you join others in doing good, rather than trying to do it all alone?

> The session reminds us that those who fear their Lord will be driven to Paradise in groups, and Surah Al-'Asr describes believers who advise each other to truth and to patience. Replanting a neglected tree is often easier by joining an existing community activity than by starting something alone. For example: instead of running my own project, I could volunteer at an activity already happening at my local mosque, and pray there more often to stay connected.

## My action plan

- [ ] I will score my Seven Trees of Balance this week and choose one tree to grow.
- [ ] I will plant one small seed in that tree and repeat it for 30 days.
- [ ] I will set aside protected time for my family that other things do not crowd out.
- [ ] I will say La ilaha illallah with presence, clearing out whatever I have put in Allah's place.

- [ ] When a "what if" comes, I will say "Allah has decreed" and turn to what I can do now.
- [ ] I will keep up my long periods of silence and leave everyone, and my own body, better than I found them.